

MARLENA A. BRANHAM

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EDUCATION

University of Michigan, School of Information

Master of Science in Information, User Research & Design | May 2025

Graduate Certificate in Advanced Studies of Innovation and Entrepreneurship, U-M College of Engineering

University of Michigan, College of Literature, Science, and the Arts

Bachelor of Arts, Biopsychology, Cognition, and Neuroscience | December 2021

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Product & Digital Strategy Consultant | Independent Consulting | Remote | November 2025 - Present

- Translate client goals into digital strategies, website content, marketing plans, and execution-ready deliverables across aviation, beauty, legal services, and entrepreneurship.
- Manage concurrent priorities, stakeholder feedback, and client communications; use AI-assisted workflows to support content development and implementation.

Product Strategist | Herbtropia | Michigan / Arizona | September 2023 - Present

- Lead product discovery and experience strategy for a wellness platform connecting users with practitioners, events, and educational resources.
- Conducted and synthesized 150+ user, practitioner, and stakeholder interviews to map pain points, define user needs, refine customer segments, and prioritize MVP features and service workflows.
- Translated research into problem and solution maps, user flows, high-fidelity Figma concepts, practitioner onboarding processes, submission workflows, and a phased product roadmap.
- Communicated findings, tradeoffs, and product decisions to mentors, funders, practitioners, and non-technical stakeholders through pitches, roadmaps, prototypes, and implementation plans.

Product Development Intern | Ann Arbor Sprak | Ann Arbor, MI | May 2024 - August 2024

- Gathered executive requirements and conducted product, market, systems, and data analysis for APT Solar Solutions' smart-city expansion and product-development planning.
- Synthesized technical, business, operational, and customer information into clear recommendations supporting deployment decisions, market positioning, and long-term product strategy.

Graduate Student Instructor | University of Michigan | Ann Arbor, MI | January 2025 – May 2025

- Mentored 60+ students in Online Communities on digital ecosystems, moderation strategy, community behavior, and inclusive participation; created feedback structures that supported clear iteration.
- Guided students through analytical problem-solving, evaluation trade-offs, and iterative improvement under changing constraints.

Business Strategy & UX Consultant | HappierMe | Remote | January 2024 - January 2025

- Evaluated a mental health mobile app through interaction mapping, user interviews, persona development, competitive analysis, Nielsen heuristic evaluation, and usability testing with first-time users.
- Identified issues across onboarding, navigation, search, forum safety, and guided journaling and translated findings into prioritized, engineering-ready product recommendations.
- Extended research into go-to-market and community operations by helping launch a multi-campus ambassador program across 10+ schools.

SELECTED PROJECTS

Safe Drinking Water Policy & Information Access Research | August 2023 - December 2023

- Synthesized 200+ research notes, expert insights, and interview findings through affinity mapping to identify communication gaps and resource inequities across Michigan schools.

SKILLS

UX: User-centered design, User-centered interaction, user interviews, usability testing, heuristic evaluation, affinity mapping, personas, user flows, information architecture, Figma prototyping, inclusive design, research synthesis.

Tools: Figma, Adobe Creative Suite, Qualtrics, HTML, CSS, JavaScript, Python, SQL, Google Apps Script, Google Workspace, AI-assisted workflows.